

tion of adult obese.

Doctors say several factors contribute to the rise in obesity in urban India, ranging from rapidly changing lifestyles and increased consumption of processed foods and high-sugar beverages to little physical activity. Genetic predisposition is another layer.

“There has certainly been a rise in the demand for weight-loss drugs. But weight-loss medications should be taken only under medical supervision, and the patient needs to comply with all other instructions given by the physician along with regular follow-ups,” says Dr Pradeep Chowbey, Chairman, Max Institute of Laparoscopic, Endoscopic, Bariatric Surgery & Allied Surgical Specialities. “Patients, unfortunately, see this as an easy fix and want to try this option even if they do not fit the criteria for these medications. Even people who are slightly overweight want to try these medications as an easy fix to stay in shape,” he says.

HOW THE ANTI-OBESITY PILLS STACK UP

The intersection of medical advancements and consumer aspirations has made the battle against obesity the collective aim of patients, doctors and pharmaceutical companies.

Weight loss drugs have different mechanisms (*see box ‘Fighting the Flab’*). Some like the glucagon-like peptide-1 (GLP-1) agonists, work by making your stomach feel full by mimicking the hormone GLP-1. Some, like phentermine, suppress appetite and increase the metabolic rate, making you lose weight. Some, like orlistat, decrease fat absorption in the gut, reducing calorie intake and aiding in weight loss.

Globally recognised weight loss drugs include Novo Nordisk’s Wegovy/Ozempic (semaglutide) and Saxenda (liraglutide), which influence the GLP-1 hormone, promoting fullness and reducing food intake. Eli Lilly’s Mounjaro (tirzepatide) combines GLP-

INDIA'S ANTI-OBESITY DRUG MARKET



Despite the market's single-digit growth since 2019, the launch of semaglutide (Rybelsus, the oral form of Ozempic) in January 2022 was a game changer



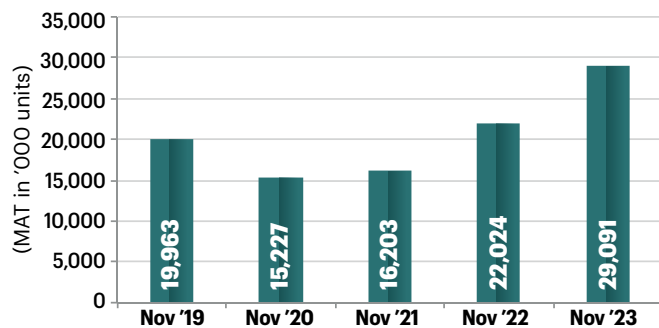
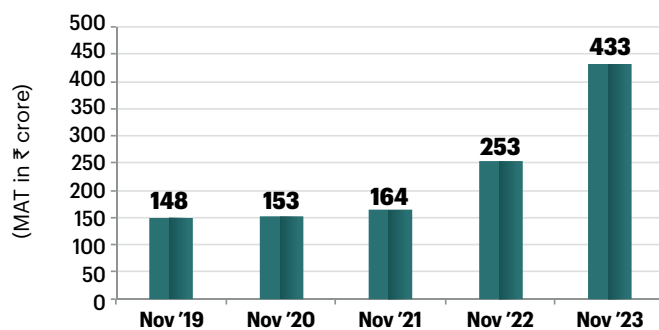
The market has almost tripled in terms of value and doubled in terms of volume if one compares the MAT of November 2023 to MAT of 2021



The quick surge in demand may not be proportional with the increase in cases, but it may indicate a greater readiness to treat obesity



The onset of chronic cardio-diabetic conditions at a younger age increases the duration of consumption of these drugs



MAT (MOVING ANNUAL TOTAL) INDICATES TOTAL SALES FIGURES OF THE PREVIOUS 12 MONTHS

SOURCE PHARMATRAC MAT NOV 23